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up to 25 Mbps), hundreds of channels cannot be broadcast on it simultaneously. Every channel change request by the user goes to the content server, resulting in a delay while changing a channel.

Currently, IPTV is in rollout phase and its broadcasters include BSNL, MTNL, Airtel and Reliance (only in select cities in India).

Satellite TV: Constant signal

In satellite TV (commonly known as DTH), the signal is received using a dish antenna installed in the user's premises. The specifications of a dish antenna may differ for each broadcaster, with some broadcasters using bigger dishes or varying numbers of low-noise blocks (LNBs). The dish antenna receives the signal in encrypted form from the satellite and is installed in direct alignment with the location of the satellite. Also, an STB is placed inside the viewer's home. The RG-6 coaxial cable connects the STB to the antenna for signal reception. The STB works only after a certain amount of signal quality and strength has been acquired, which is fine-tuned by using the signal meter during installation of the dish antenna.

As in the case of cable TV, the STB receiver is used for decrypting the signal to facilitate TV viewing for the user.

In DTH, the content is directly controlled by the broadcaster and the viewer can pay and watch the channels/bouquets of his choice. The perks of DVD-quality signal and stereo sound are implicitly available to the viewer in this medium. The most remarkable advantage of DTH is the constant availability (24/7) of the signal as there is no intermediate operator between the broadcaster and the viewer, unlike in IPTV and digital cable TV.

DTH broadcasters in India include Tata Sky, Bharti Airtel, Sun Direct, DD Direct, Reliance Big TV and Dish TV.

Digital cable TV rules the roost

Satellite TV appears to be promising and has been successful in claiming a piece of the market share for itself but cable TV still has the highest number of subscribers.

Cable TV was one of the earliest systems to be deployed worldwide against the conventional terrestrial system, and it started with the analogue system. Signals from various satellites were received at the multi-system operator (MSO) end through multiple high-end dish antennae. These signals were then multiplexed at the MSO end and finally transmitted to homes via coaxial cables. The signals were amplified by signal amplifiers placed at strategic points in the cable network.

The whole network was managed by distributors authorised by MSOs according to area divisions. However, since the signals were analogue and transmitted in a clear format, a lot of noise would get accumulated over the network before reaching the end user. Also, it was common for signals to be stolen. People would place hooks on the wire in order to freeloader off another's signal, which added to the noise, making TV viewing miserable for those who actually paid for the service.

Now, with the onset of digital cable TV, cable TV viewing has become vastly different from what it used to be in with analogue cable TV. With digital cable TV, all the user needs to do is install an STB at home in order to enjoy the luxury of choosing from a host of channels. The biggest advantage of digital cable TV is its crystal-clear video quality and stereo-like audio. The signal distribution model still remains the same but the signal is now encrypted and can only be decrypted by STB. So, even if someone tries to form a signal leakage point, it will be of no use because the signal is nothing but a noise without subscription from an MSO.

Leading cable TV broadcasters in